How I rebuilt my second brain in one afternoon.

A field guide to the free stack that lives on a laptop, syncs to a phone, and updates itself while I sleep. Three tools. Zero subscriptions. One folder of markdown files.

TOOLS	COST	SETUP
3 total	$0 /mo	1 afternoon

01 · PREMISE

Your second brain should update itself.

Most second-brain systems ask you to do the work. Open the app, type the note, tag it, link it, review it weekly. That's the opposite of what a second brain should be.

I wanted one that wrote itself most of the time. That read my Readwise every morning and filed what mattered. That drafted my daily note while I was still asleep. That versioned every change so I could see when a number moved and what moved it.

Claude made it possible. Obsidian made it readable. Git made it portable. Three tools, one afternoon, zero monthly spend. Everything a twenty-dollar-a-month PKM subscription promises, plus the ability to let an agent write into it overnight.

> *A second brain should do work for you, not ask for it.*

02 · ARCHITECTURE

Six parts, one folder.

Every piece below lives in or writes to the same folder on disk. That's the discipline that makes the whole thing coherent. Swap any one part for a better one and the rest keeps working.

01

Folder

Plain markdown files in one directory. That's the vault. No database, no magic format.

02

Obsidian

The reader and writer. Desktop app on the Mac, mobile app on the phone. Wikilinks, graph view, search, free.

03

GitHub

The spine. The folder is a Git repo, pushed to a private GitHub repository. History is free and forever.

04

Git Plugin

Obsidian's community plugin auto-commits and auto-pulls every ten minutes on both devices.

05

Routines

Scheduled Claude tasks that clone the repo, edit a file, commit, and push. No laptop uptime required.

06

Phone

Where you actually read the output. Coffee-and-couch, not laptop-and-desk.

03 · MEMORY

Obsidian reads the folder. That's the whole job.

Obsidian doesn't own your data. It points at a folder and renders the markdown files inside it. That's the killer feature nobody leads with.

It treats the folder as a **vault** and gives you wikilinks, a graph view, a mobile app, a global search, and a templates system. All free. No account required. Your notes never leave the folder.

Swap Obsidian for a different markdown editor tomorrow and the vault survives intact. Nothing is locked in. The folder is the thing. Obsidian is a lens.

```
# the vault on disk
claude-vault/
  Daily/
    2026-04-17.md
  Readwise Triage/
    2026-04-17.md
  YouTube/
    Harry Verity/
    Lownie Clips/
  AI-Founders Notes/
  .git/  ← pushed to GitHub on every change
```

The folder comes first. Obsidian comes second. The order matters because it says your notes are independent of any app.

04 · SPINE

Git is what makes the whole thing work.

Obsidian looks like the system. It isn't. Git is. Without Git, you have a nice note-taking app on one device. With Git, you have a real system.

Every save commits. Every commit pushes to a private GitHub repo. Within minutes, that commit is pulled onto your phone and every cloud agent you run can see it. The same vault, visible in three places, identical content.

History comes free. When a number in your stats file shifted last Tuesday, run `git log` and you can see the exact commit that changed it. You can check what you believed about yourself on any date in the past.

> *The vault isn't the files. It's the commit history.*

Keep the repo **private**. Your notes contain your thinking. GitHub's free tier gives you unlimited private repos with 500MB storage, which is more than a markdown vault will ever need.

05 · SYNC

The trick that makes Obsidian work on a phone.

The standard Obsidian setup on mobile is painful. No sync, or a four-dollar-a-month Obsidian Sync add-on.

There's a better way. Install the community plugin **Obsidian Git** on both desktop and mobile. Configure auto-pull every ten minutes, auto-push on change. Git is now the sync engine.

Your phone sees new commits minutes after your laptop pushes them. Your laptop sees new commits from your phone the same way. A scheduled Claude routine running in Anthropic's cloud can write a note, commit, push, and the file lands on your phone while you're still making coffee.

What Obsidian Git actually does. It wraps `git pull` and `git push` in a three-screen config UI. Free. Three minutes to install. Turns a note-taking app into a real-time multi-device system.

06 · AUTOMATION

Routines that write to your vault while you sleep.

Once the folder syncs via Git, anything that can commit can update your vault. A scheduled Claude routine clones the repo, edits a file, commits, pushes. No laptop required. The Max plan includes fifteen of these a day.

I have three running. Every morning at 07:00, Claude writes my daily note from my Notion tasks and yesterday's reflection. At 07:30, it ranks my Readwise saves into must-read, summary, and archive. On Mondays, it pulls analytics for all three of my YouTube channels.

Three more are queued. A weekly fitness review. A Friday Mac cleanup that files loose Desktop and Downloads junk into the right project folder. An inbox zero digest that reads Gmail and triages by urgency.

> *The vault is still updating. My laptop is still off.*

07 · BUILD ORDER

Do it in this sequence.

Skip any step and the next one gets harder. Follow the sequence and the whole thing takes under an afternoon.

```
# the afternoon, in order
01  make a folder on disk
02  open Obsidian, point it at the folder
03  create a private repo on GitHub
04  git init the folder, push to GitHub
05  install Obsidian Git plugin (desktop)
06  install Obsidian Git plugin (phone)
07  configure auto-pull + auto-push
08  add one scheduled Claude routine ←
```

The last step is the one most people skip. Don't. Even one routine that auto-writes a single file proves the whole system works. Everything else grows from there.

08 · WHAT FIRST

Start with the daily note.

The daily note is the right first routine for three reasons. It's the file you open most, so a broken routine is immediately visible. It's short, so you can prompt it well on the first try. And it compounds: once Claude is writing a daily note, it's reading yesterday's reflection, noticing patterns, and flagging what drifted.

Mine runs at 07:00 Bali. It reads my Notion tasks, my calendar, and yesterday's Evening Reflection if I wrote one. It drafts a Morning Brief in the note. I open Obsidian with coffee and the brief is already there.

A good daily-note routine is the whole "second brain" payoff in one file. Get that right before building anything else. The rest is just copy-paste.

The daily-note routine, next.

The next issue breaks down my 07:00 daily-note routine line by line. The prompt, the Notion integration, the commit logic. Everything you'd need to copy it.

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